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Moving towards peace, compassion and empathy through semiotic enquiry

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In our interconnected world, exposure to hate, fear, violence and adversarial communication is commonplace. Yet, this exposure underscores the urgent need for a more just, peaceful, and inclusive society. While research stresses the importance of nurturing peace, compassion and empathy for enhanced well-being and social justice, these three terms are rarely discussed at length in linguistics and communication studies. Little systematic work explores how language and semiotic resources actualise these ideals across contexts. This special issue, grounded in systemic functional linguistics, addresses this gap. It aims to contribute to a more just world, promote non-violent efforts for social justice, and lay the foundation for future research on the semiotics of peace, compassion and empathy. This paper outlines key definitions and contributions.

Keywords: peace, compassion, empathy, semiotics, systemic functional linguistics, multimodality, discourse analysis, corpus linguistics, digital communication, morality

1. Introduction

In the past two decades, humanities and social sciences research on the topics of peace, compassion, and empathy has experienced a significantly renewed interest (e.g. Höijer 2003; Webel and Galtung 2007; Gruen 2015). Yet, linguistic research on these topics, particularly within the tradition of systemic functional linguistics (hereafter SFL), is relatively limited. What this special issue (hereafter SI) is about is bringing the three topics together, acknowledging the intersections between them (as demonstrated in the papers of this SI), in contribution to the United Nations Sustainable Development Goal 16 (UN SDG 16) which aims to promote justice, peace and inclusion. The aim of this SI is to contribute to our (individuals' and organisations') understanding, promotion and awareness of the specific functions of language and other semiotic resources to express and advance peace, compassion and empathy in everyday life and in other theatres of social engagement. It is a timely step towards illustrating how linguistic research itself constitutes a powerful resource for the advancement of peace, compassion and empathy, and how it can inform designs for social change. Based on this linguistic research, and in pursuit of fostering a more inclusive and understanding world, the SI shares and showcases how the application of linguistic theory emerges as a beacon of hope.

Through the realms of semiotic enquiry, the SI illuminates the profound ways in which language can be harnessed to cultivate peace, compassion and empathy. It delves into the semantic and grammatical intricacies across various genres. By examining texts from diverse fields including political science, media, human rights and medicine, along with everyday casual conversation, we aim to shed light on the linguistic choices driving these concepts. Through this exploration, we seek to foster a deeper comprehension of our shared humanity and how we can enhance the quality of our life, as well as the life of other beings in the animal world.

Grounding their investigations in the traditions of SFL, the articles in the SI draw on a model of language that is oriented towards using linguistics to address social issues (e.g. inequalities, lack of freedom) (Halliday 2008). This functional theory of language gives us a perspective of language as action as well as a reflection of the society within which it occurs, and where meaning-making is grounded in social practice (Halliday 1978; Halliday with Matthiessen 2014). That is, a text analysed within the SFL tradition is viewed as being a semantic unit that is “functional” in the sense that it is “doing a job in some context” (Halliday and Hasan 1985: 10). This sensitises us to the patterning and functioning of choices made in text. This perspective of meaning making is powerful in contexts where users of language as well as other semiotic resources are strategically and deliberately hindering or

otherwise advancing understanding and social justice in order to promote peaceful and inclusive societies.

Another point of significance of the SI resides in its triune focus on “peace, compassion and empathy”. Unlike previous work that attempts to address each topic at a time, the focus of the SI on this triune acknowledges the interconnections and the relationship between the three. Having a sense of common humanity, when witnessing or learning about the suffering of other people, arouses empathy and compassion for the plight of the needy and most vulnerable humans (Bandura 2016: 414). Empathy establishes the connection between us, and is the gateway to compassion – moving from feeling *with* to feeling *for* (Dowling 2018). Research into human rights and conflict resolution also considers compassion and building compassion to be a critical component to peacebuilding practices and helping social groups establish common grounds (e.g. human rights among conflicting parties). Compassion, in this sense, is “a social enterprise, promoting a sense of bonding with others” (Rothbart and Allen 2019: 376) and serving as an enabler of achieving social justice and peace. United Nations Human Rights Council’s mandate holders have emphasised that social justice fosters peace and peace enables social justice (de Zayas 2015). It is this interconnection between the three concepts and their influence on various walks of life which the SI emphasises.

The SI, as such, contributes to the linguistic conceptualisation of peace, compassion and empathy in different contexts and text types (summarised in Section 3) and how these concepts are operationalised by social actors to advance particular goals. The SI paves the way for leaders, peace-builders and organisations to revise their discourses, for social movements to refine their resistance and change projects, and for educators to reflect on their approaches towards their students – based on the proposed analytical models. The SI establishes the linguistic modelling of compassion development and empathy development. It also informs those working in the health sector, education, peacebuilding, politics, social movements, social media activism and more (as demonstrated in the articles of the SI) how to improve wellbeing and foster social justice. Through its choice of datasets and applications of a broad range of SFL theoretical and analytical frameworks as well as other linguistic tools, such as corpus linguistics, the SI contributes to the overarching deployment of linguistic analysis as a powerful vehicle for expressing, negotiating and understanding diverse perspectives and actions in the service of social justice.

The insights of the SI are expected to be of broad appeal by the mere fact that the language of peace, compassion and empathy can be applied at micro and macro levels across

the many contexts we humans find ourselves in throughout life. In a micro sense, being able to listen to and respond with empathy, act compassionately and contribute to a peaceful experience with intimate partners, families, closest friends and acquaintances enriches the most local of social networks. Similarly, from a macro perspective, as intimate networks extend into larger networks through professional, organisational and institutional involvement, on through to national and global networks, the reach and impact of the language of peace, compassion and empathy extends exponentially. With more people having the ability to humanise with empathy, thus motivating acts of compassion, the more likely there will be a mutual desire for peace and harmony. Towards that end, there is an expectation that this SI will be of particular interest to educators as they strive to bring compassion and the language of peace into classrooms around the world. Through education, people can learn how to mean peacefully and they can benefit from doing something positive in the midst of global upheaval. The SI is a compassionate response to our collective desire to make the world a better place.

2. Defining “peace”, “compassion” and “empathy” in the special issue

An overarching theme of this SI is the notion of peace and how it is enacted or realised in discourse and other forms of semiosis. To begin, “peace” is a concept that is lexicalised in many of the world’s languages (see for example, Peace23 2023). In English, the word “peace” comes via Old French from Latin *pax*. The English word is defined in the *Shorter Oxford English Dictionary* (1992) initially in relation to war and in negative terms as *freedom from* (e.g. war, commotion, disturbance) or *absence of* (e.g. noise) before the opposite meanings are provided (e.g. security, tranquillity, quiet). This tendency to define “peace” in binary terms establishes “peace” as the marked choice in a peace-war dichotomy despite the independent values and social processes that “peace” encompasses as distinct from “war” (Clyne 1987; Ferguson 2008; Hodges 2013).

Looking at the etymology of “peace” in English and other languages allows us to see traces of meaning that provide some insight into the current meanings encapsulated in “peace”. For example, *pax*, while having the meaning of peace and harmony for Romans, also referred to a treaty to end a war (Lewis and Short 1879) or “peace through subjugation” (Clyne 1987:78). A related word in English, from the same Latin root, is “pact”, an agreement. These words have been reconstructed as the Indo-European root **pak-*, meaning

“fasten”, which has connotations of stability (Wescott 1990). Prior to “peace”, the word in English was of Germanic origin, *frith*, which is related to the word for peace in German, *Friede*. Cognates in English of *Friede* and *frith* are the words “friend” and “free” (Wescott 1990). So, “peace” can be said to encompass the notions of stability, friendship, agreement and freedom. In Hebrew and Arabic, the word for “peace” is also used as a greeting. The Hebrew word, *shalom*, and in Arabic, *salaam*, include the meanings of “completeness, wellbeing, harmony” and “wholeness” (Clyne 1987). In Sanskrit, the word for “peace”, *śānti*, *śānti*, has a range of meanings all related to inner peace (Narasimhananda 2018). This root is found in words for peace within languages of the Indian subcontinent, Sri Lanka and mainland Southeast Asia, such as Thai, Khmer and Lao. Oxford (2013: 4) identifies six dimensions of language related to peace: inner, interpersonal, intergroup, international, intercultural and the ecological. The meanings cited above represent at least four of these domains: inner, interpersonal, intergroup and international.

A preliminary corpus analysis of the lemma “peace*” was performed drawing from the News on the Web (NOW) Corpus (<https://www.english-corpora.org/nlw/>) containing 15.7 billion + words and consisting of web-based newspapers and magazines from 2010 to the present time (created 2/9/22) and the English web (enTenTen20) Corpus (<https://app.sketchengine.eu>) consisting of texts gathered from the Internet containing 36.5 billion+ words (created 1/9/2022). In terms of word class, in both corpora, the three most frequent occurrences of “peace*” was first as the noun “peace” followed, with a considerable decline in frequency, by the adjective “peaceful” and then the adverb “peacefully”. Nouns collocating with “peace*” include “process”, “security”, “talk”, “mind” and “stability”; verbs include “rest”, “bring” and “make”, and adjectives include “lasting”, “regional”, “national” and “global”. An analysis of the first one hundred clauses of each corpus found the following patterns of uses of “peace*” in the nominal group (see Table 1). The examples also illustrate some of the domains of peace cited above.

Table 1. Patterns of “peace*” in the nominal group

Patterns	Examples
as Thing	peace and security, peace and stability, lasting peace, peace of mind
as Epithet	peaceful demonstrations, peaceful revolution, peaceful place
as Classifier	peace process, peace talks

as Qualifier	justice of the peace, chances for peace
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With regard to participant roles in the clause, the lemma “peace*” occurred most frequently in attributive clauses as Attribute, in material clauses as Goal or Scope (or as elements in the nominal group), as Token or Value and as an element in circumstantial elements of the clause (see examples in Table 2 below).

Table 2. Examples of “peace*” in the clause

Participant role	Examples
Attribute	It was <i>peaceful</i>. The demonstrations are <i>peaceful</i>. which stands between the extremes of power and <i>peace</i>
Goal	<i>peace</i> has been restored in the region. President Anwar Sadat, the first Arab leader to make <i>peace</i> with Israel, when the US ramped up <i>peace</i> talks with the Taliban
Scope	there is One who can bring <i>peace</i> people may resort to the past to find <i>peace</i> whether the military should focus on <i>peacekeeping</i> or <i>peacemaking</i>
Token	Thus does liberal <i>peace</i> become the continuation of war The Afghan <i>peace</i> process presents a historic opportunity for peace in the region.
Value	true religious leaders stand for <i>peace</i> The theme was shanti, which means <i>peace</i>. The Afghan peace process presents a historic opportunity for <i>peace</i> in the region.

Circumstance	
Cause:purpose	<i>for peace</i> and good will; for your own <i>peace</i> of mind
Location:place	Visitors...can sketch or paint in the <i>peace</i> and quiet
Manner: means	that the two countries are resolved to settle their differences by <i>peaceful</i> means

To summarise these results, “peace*” is frequently associated with states of being as well as something that needs to be enacted, as in *making* peace. However, a more in-depth corpus analysis of the lemma “peace*” might be more revelatory.

Given these differing strands of meanings – that is, peace considered in relation to conflict and violence and the impact that war and violence has on humanity as opposed to inner peace, tranquillity, friendship, agreement, wholeness, wellbeing, peace as freedom *from* rather than freedom *to*, and peace in relation to humanity’s relationship with animals and the natural world – various fields of enquiry have emerged to promote peace. Peace studies, also referred to as peace and conflict studies, identifies peace in terms of negative and positive peace – negative peace being the absence of physical violence, and positive peace as social justice to resist and renovate all areas of structural violence (Galtung 1969; Webel and Galtung 2007; Standish et al. 2021). This field of study has influenced other disciplines, giving rise to various sub-disciplines such as peace linguistics (e.g. Gomes de Matos 2000, 2014), peace sociolinguistics (e.g. Friedrich 2007; Trester 2013), peace education (e.g. Harris 2004), peace psychology (e.g. Sapio and Zamperini 2007) and peace journalism (e.g. Fourie 2012). Many researchers have called for a greater focus on language and linguistics in the quest for peace (e.g. Clyne 1987; Wenden 2007; Kruger 2012; Oxford 2013), underscoring the importance of language in peace and nonviolence. This focus on language, discourse and other forms of semiosis has great potential to inform approaches to conflict resolution (see Ortu this issue) and peacebuilding activities, such as negotiation, mediation, non-violent communication (see Thomson and Fryer, this issue), counselling, and reconciliation (see Martin and Cruz, this issue), amongst others. Since the actions of peace and conflict are invariably performed through linguistic and other semiotic acts, this focus on semiosis is apposite.

Attending to the language of peace needs to also take account of discourse. This opens the way for analytical frameworks such as (i) critical discourse analysis (CDA) which

seeks to uncover ideological processes that entrench discrimination and inequality in society (e.g. Chouliaraki and Fairclough 1999; Wodak and Meyer 2009; Martin 2012[2000]), and (ii) positive discourse analysis (PDA), focusing on progressive discourses that challenge and resist the dominant, oppressive discourses and empower the marginalised and dispossessed (Hughes 2018) (see Wijeyewardene; Martin and Cruz; Etaywe, Dreyfus and Han this issue) and discourses that seek to enlighten, empower and emancipate (Janks and Ivanič 1992; Martin 2012 [2004]; Bartlett 2012, 2018) (see Thomson, Fryer, Ortu, this issue). SFL, as an “applied linguistics” (e.g. Halliday 1985, 2008; Martin 2012[2000]; Matthiessen 2012), has informed many of the theorists cited above. Martin (2012:1) interprets the concept of an applied linguistics as “a commitment to intervene in social semiotic processes in the interests of social justice”. The theoretical approach to language as metafunctional has made an important contribution to the study of discourses of peace and conflict in CDA and PDA, with three meanings (Martin 2012[2000]): ideational meanings that construe power (or lack of it) through analysis of TRANSITIVITY and AGENCY (see Wijeyewardene; Martin and Cruz this issue), interpersonal meanings that enact power through the resources of APPRAISAL (see Martin and Cruz; Etaywe; Fryer; Dreyfus and Han; Thomson; Ortu this issue), and textual meanings that naturalise power through patterns of information, THEME and NEW (see e.g. Thomson, this issue).

The notion of Design (Kress 2000) is an important focus for PDA, taking the emphasis off the critique of texts that discriminate and marginalise, which has been the predominant focus for CDA, and concentrating more on new or renovated discourses in which users become “the remakers, transformers, of sets of representational resources – rather than users of stable systems” (Kress 2000: 160). Resistance to stable, dominant social structures is thus one crucial area of interest for PDA. As Hughes (2018:196) argues, “focusing on resistance calls our attention to the agency of individuals engaged in reshaping structural constraints. In other words, analysing resistant discourse entails design” (see Wijeyewardene, Etaywe, Dreyfus and Han, this issue). Equally important for PDA and the concept of Design is the focus on successful forms of peaceful communication that can be passed on and deployed in a variety of contexts to build more peaceful relationships (see e.g. Thomson; Ortu this issue).

Martin views CDA and PDA in terms of a complementarity: a “yin/yang” perspective (2012[2004]: 282), in which he acknowledges the need for both approaches in the analysis of discourse. Indeed “bringing injustices to light is the first step towards their resolution” (Bartlett 2012:226), but since there has already been so much work on deconstruction, Martin

calls for a greater focus on more constructive and progressive semiotic activity that promotes social change. Many of the papers in this SI engage with these approaches to the analysis of discourse, and Wijeyewardene and Martin and Cruz (this issue) demonstrate the value of the complementary perspectives in discourse analysis.

Also of importance in a study of discourses of peace, compassion and empathy is the need for more in-depth understanding of the social context within which discourses are produced and whether or how discourses have been accepted by marginalised and oppressed groups and are effective in creating social change (Bartlett 2018). A number of papers in this SI engage with the social context either in the response to particular social structures or the uptake by participants to express their agency to agitate for social change (e.g. Dreyfus and Han; Etaywe; Martin and Cruz; Wijeyewardene this issue). This can occur on various levels of interaction. For example, a study by Bartlett concludes that PDA needs to explore collaborative discourses – when two sides get together and find commonalities – “third spaces” that lead to “localised hybrid discourses” (Bartlett 2012: 217; see also Thomson this issue). However, times of conflict often present intractable positions that make the production of these third spaces impossible (Wijeyewardene; Etaywe this issue).

Peace as a goal is a worthy ambition, but how is this to be achieved? If peace is to be considered the goal, then compassion and empathy must be a necessary part of the means to realise this goal. Both terms appear in various literature on peace and on discourse analytic methods to achieve peace. For example, according to Oxford (2013: 8, 10, 45), peace is achievable through empathy. Galtung (2011, cited in Connors 2016) also defines peace as the “ability to handle conflict with empathy, nonviolence and creativity”, and Hodges (2013: 4) argues that rather than having a desire to resort to violence, humans are more likely to display empathy and compassion. Compassion, then, is also a key element in the pursuit of peace. Rather than just a state, peace needs to be considered as an action by agents expressed through acts of compassion (Oxford 2013:15). The Vietnamese Buddhist monk and peace activist, Thich Nhat Hanh (2008[2003]:8), states that “[c]ultivating peace means cultivating understanding and cultivating compassion.” As Bartlett (2012: 229-230) argues, “fostering empathy with an audience is the essential intermediary stage between comprehension and uptake” – that is, understanding entails both comprehension and empathy.

Central to our exploration is, thus, the recognition of compassion as a fundamental driving force for positive, non-violent change, and as action-focused and others-centred (see Etaywe this issue). Compassion in the SI is conceptualised as a social discursive process that can be visualised on a cline or continuum where empathy (defined later in this section) is

activated first, establishing the connection between us (Dowling 2018), and compassion follows. In other words, compassion transcends our everyday emotional reactions, such as feeling *with* another's affective state, and perspective-taking or understanding – which is the focus of “empathy” (see Thomson this issue). Compassion expresses institutionalised feelings. That is, it goes beyond emotions triggered by witnessing, hearing or learning about the suffering of others, entering the realm of shared community and/or universal norms, values and ethics. This entails what should (not) be done or said to relieve those in distress (for a more detailed discussion of the linguistic difference between affect or emotions, and institutionalised feelings, see Martin and White 2005). Compassion's essence is morally motivated responses or practices that have a social purpose – to curb violence and alleviate the suffering of other humans (as demonstrated by Etaywe this issue), as well as non-human beings (as demonstrated by Fryer this issue). Hence, a sociolinguistic investigation of compassion should examine how morality relates to not only language use but also acts of compassion (as a social meaning), as well as the social purposes of these acts. For more about (i) the relationship between morality or moral orders (e.g. freedom, justice, care, legal moral orders), agency and language use, see, e.g. Van Langenhove (2017), and (ii) the discursive construction of social purposes, see van Leeuwen (2008). The SI presents one's compassion as a human value demonstrated through effort exerted in helping those in pain or suffering (Bandura 2016); as such, to describe someone as being compassionate implies a performance-based act that is other-centred as an authentication of one's compassionate identity (Etaywe, this issue).

This conceptualisation of compassion as a morally informed practice aligns with the existing research in psychology and philosophy where compassion is presented, firstly, as a moral concern and care for others, including strangers from different continents and cultures (Höijer 2004), highlighting the morality and human basis of compassion. Compassion is, secondly, viewed as experiencing or learning about the pain or suffering of others and having the desire to alleviate their suffering through one's actions or the actions of others (Rothbart and Allen 2019). This not only underscores the action and moral agency factor in compassion but also draws our attention to the importance of language and communication in raising awareness about others' pain and, thus, in the arousal of compassion. The medium through which others' experiences are witnessed or conveyed, whether through the naked eye, language or visual communication, influences how we perceive the world and victims, get motivated, get together and compassionately act (for more, particularly, on the role of visuals in compassion, see Höijer 2004). A sociolinguistic investigation of compassion, thus, needs

to examine what framing processes and visual presentation tactics are used to construct the victims and human experiences and to influence our cognitive processes (namely, knowing and learning), how people come together, what motivates them, what values are negotiated, and what identity processes are in play (see Etaywe; Fryer this issue). The capacity of compassion and the moral agency of individuals remain dormant until activated, contingent on individuals being positioned or engaged with the plight of others (Bandura 2016: 92). The modelling of compassion development as a moral affiliation process as discussed by Etaywe (this issue) strives to demonstrate how discourse operates to activate compassion, positioning audiences, fostering moral orders and encouraging ethical actions. . For more about the relationship between positioning and morality, see, for example, Harré (2012). A third view of compassion is: “the desire and effort to alleviate the perceived suffering of others” (Bandura 2016: 92). This definition, as well as the previous ones, foregrounds motivations and (personal or collective) agency as key components for the study of compassion. This understanding of compassion as a social discursive process grounded in human values paves the way for research into “compassion as a norm”, hence understanding and mitigating suffering within a moral framework. That is, compassion holds priority, for example, in a community’s ethos regarding supporting each other to ensure everyday peace; and it has precedence in the human rights agenda of international law, including Geneva conventions, and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (Rothbart and Allen 2019). That is, compassion assists in creating a reality of “interdependent ethos in which participants derive their self-regard and well-being from improving each other’s lives [...] and working towards improving the conditions of life in society at large” (Bandura 2016: 94). In addition, compassion grounded in common humanity and humanitarian ethics has a transformative power to support the needy and “curb violence” (ibid.) such as that in the occupied Palestinian territories. These international laws and conventions are grounded morally on the claim of universal dignity and come with an imperative to investigate and mitigate systemic vulnerability of certain categories of people, such as the wounded, prisoners of war, ethnic minorities, civilian non-combatants, and racial and religious groups subject to the crime of genocide. This also presents the norm of compassion as being an institutionalised and “systemic” act, serving as a driving force that can manifest in a pattern of actions and practices of relieving those in distress, conflict resolution, interpersonal mediation, school-based conflict resolution programs (Rothbart and Allen 2019), non-violent resistance and social media activism (see e.g. Etaywe; Fryer this issue). Given that such institutionalised compassion is grounded in common human values, which encourage in-grouping rather than

out-grouping and exclusion (Bandura 2016), an investigation into the evaluative language (e.g. Martin and White 2005) in multimodal texts, within a “progressive” discourse analysis project (Hughes 2018), and “communion affiliation” as in-grouping strategy (Etaywe and Zappavigna 2023) are proposed and demonstrated as relevant linguistic tools for the examination of compassion in the SI. The SI seeks to unearth the semiotic mechanisms that enable us to express, embody, develop and evoke compassion through discourse.

The conceptualisation of compassion as a value, attribute and being action-oriented is also evidenced by a preliminary investigation of the word “compassion” that involved an examination in OED and three corpora (for more details, see the Semiotics of Peace, Compassion and Empathy SIG archive). The investigation in the *Oxford English Dictionary* reveals that the word refers, inter alia, to a noun of action, fellow feeling, and the feeling when a person is moved by the suffering or distress of another and by the desire to relieve it. The preliminary investigation of the use of the lemma “compassion*” also extended to exploring the concordance lines within the 1.5-billion-word Coronavirus Corpus (<https://www.english-corpora.org/corona/>) The corpus’s data is taken from approximately 1.9 million texts from Jan 2020–Dec 2022. The texts are typically web-based news genre reporting on the pandemic and sourced from online magazines and newspapers across 20 different English-speaking countries. The focus of this initial analysis was on the “compassion*” word class and its evaluative significance, given the interconnectedness of lexis and grammar and to highlight the inherent values in the lexical item itself. The examination shows that the lemma “compassion” is predominantly realised as a noun and adjective. “Compassionate” serves as an evaluative lexical item that describes *behaviour*, implying judgement, and attributes to *things*, indicating appreciation. The concept of compassion can thus be initially described as a feature of appreciation or a characteristic of being (e.g. “*compassionate* approach”), a judgement or a state of behaviour (e.g. “*compassionate* leader”), and/or an ideation (e.g. a value, idea, abstraction – e.g. “*compassion* of Jesus”, “city of *compassion*”). In-depth corpus linguistic examination of this concept, including a collocation analysis and a key word in context (KWIC) analysis, is provided in Etaywe’s work (this issue).

The preliminary investigation has also extended to the following Sketch Engine corpora, which were examined for syntactic patterns: British Academic Spoken English Corpus (BASE, 1,477,281 words) and British Academic Written English Corpus (BAWE, 6,968,089 words). A closer look at the Word Sketch on Sketch Engine reveals “compassion” (in italics) in different patterns, summarised and exemplified in Table 3. These patterns, using

the default traditional descriptive grammatical categories of the Word Sketch, include compassion as subject, compassion as object, compassion as modifier, and compassion as predicate. Using the SFL descriptive terms, the word often appears to function at the group level as a Thing (e.g. *compassion* and empathy), Classifier (e.g. *compassion* fatigue), Epithet (e.g. *compassionate* role) and Qualifier (e.g. spirit of *compassion*). Since the Word Sketch does not provide a fuller context, the analysis of the lemma for its Participant role in the clause has included the first two hundred concordance lines of the Coronavirus Corpus. The analysis reveals that the lemma “compassion*” occurred in a clause as a Participant (Attribute, Value, Goal, Scope, and Token) and as the Thing in the Circumstance of Manner as in the following examples:

- (1) South Africans are courageous and *compassionate*... (Attribute)
- (2) We should show *compassion* especially during this time of COVID-19.
(Value)
- (3) I can model *compassion* and kindness to my kids. (Goal)
- (4) The world needs to focus on peace, love, *compassion* and understanding.
(Scope)
- (5) The second person I met who embodied a Christmas-like *compassion* was Carolynne. (Token)
- (6) Companies are treating their employees with empathy and *compassion*.
(Circumstance: manner: means)

Table 3. “Compassion” word sketch

Pattern	Examples
Modifier of Noun	<i>compassion</i> fatigue; manner based on <i>compassion</i>
Modified as Noun	genuine <i>compassion</i> ; maternal <i>compassion</i>
Compassion as Object	felt a sudden <i>compassion</i> ; emphasise <i>compassion</i> ; sees <i>compassion</i> as the highest cardinal virtue
Preposition Object (by ...)	fashioned by a <i>compassion</i>
Compassion as Subject	<i>compassion</i> destroys evolution...; <i>compassion</i> which counters man’s corruption...; <i>Compassion</i> is real and true for the most enlightened souls.

Compassion in Prepositional Phrase	Sub-categories	
	For compassion	Disregard <i>for</i> human <i>compassion</i>
	Of compassion (‘compassion’ as an element of the postmodifier)	spirit <i>of compassion</i> ; duty <i>of compassion</i>
	With compassion	Tempered <i>with compassion</i> ; performed <i>with compassion</i>
	On compassion	attacks <i>on compassion</i>
	From compassion	Knowledge <i>from compassion</i>
Predicate (of e.g. act)	motive was <i>compassion</i>	

Given that compassion intersects with empathy, and as language is also implicated in behaving empathically, it is helpful to look at both the lexicogrammatical arrangement and the meaning of empathy as a backdrop before looking closely at how it is instantiated linguistically as a form of social behaviour. In terms of lexicogrammatical arrangement, a preliminary concordancing investigation of the lemma “empath*” indicates the class(es) of word that “empath*” typically selects, and the company or co-textual environment in which it occurs. To investigate this, the Coronavirus Corpus was selected due to the context of the sickness and suffering during the pandemic as it was expected to contain a significant number of examples of “empath*” in text.

The most frequent class of “empath*” was as the noun, “empathy”. Significantly below this was the adjective, “empathetic”, followed by the verb “empathise”/ “empathize” and the adjective “empathic”. When considering the participant roles in the transitivity structure of the clause, “empath*” functions most frequently as Attribute, followed by Goal, then Value (see Table 4).

Table 4. Participant roles of “empath*” in the clause

Participant role	Example from the corpus
Attribute	.. to be <i>empathetic</i> and mindful...

Goal	.. engage more deeply, build <i>empathy</i> and create bridges..
Value	Chancy brings a raw <i>empathy</i> , and gorgeous, intimate voice

When collocates of “empath*” were investigated, the most common collocates were closed set lexical items of “and”, “of”, “the”, “to” and “for”, indicating that the location of “empath*” is most usually within the noun group and the prepositional phrase. When present in the nominal group, “empath*” functions as either the Thing, for example, “a raw *empathy*” or a Classifier as in, “our *empathy* stores”. “Empathy” co-occurs with the 1st person plural pronoun, “we” more frequently (613 times) than “I” (539 times) most likely due to the news genres in the corpus. Journalists are reporting on our behaviours with humans present in the texts, pronominally as “we”.

When considering open set lexical items, the most frequent collocates were abstract nouns, the most frequent being “compassion” (1194 times), then “understanding” (523 times), “kindness”, “respect”, “skills”, “sympathy” and “love” respectively. The most frequent process type was Relational, empath* collocating, for example with, “is”, “have”, “are”, followed by Mental, such as, “sense”, “feel”. “Empath*” collocated with a limited set of participants most frequently, “it”, followed by “we”, “people”, “I”, “you”.

This preliminary investigation provides an impression of how “empath*” is used lexicogrammatically. This arrangement supports the discussion on compassion above which describes the close connection between compassion and empathy in the psychological and philosophical literature (See section on compassion in this article). The two notions co-occur lexicogrammatically, evidencing that empathy and compassion are both implicated in the alleviation of suffering.

Turning to the semantics of “empathy”, it is worth taking a moment to tease out the differences between “empathy” and “sympathy” as these terms are often used interchangeably, which can create some confusion. Looking at the two entries in the *Macquarie Dictionary*, “empathy” is a process of *perception*, that is to say, it is about sensing appreciatively the feelings or spirit of another, while “sympathy” is an agreement or “community of like feeling”, in the sense that both parties recognise the feelings and experience them in the same way (see Table 5).

Table 5. Difference between “empathy” and “sympathy”

Empathy	Sympathy
<i>n.</i> Mental entering into the feeling or spirit of a person or thing: appreciative perception or understanding.	<i>n</i> 1. A community of or agreement in feelings, as between persons or on the part of one person with respect to another. 2. The community of feeling naturally existing between person of like tastes or opinion or of congenial dispositions. 3. The fact or the power of entering into the feelings of another, esp. in sorrow or trouble; fellow feeling, compassion or commiseration

Macquarie Dictionary (2nd edition)

To build on the dictionary definition, a psychological perspective on empathy is “understanding and participating in another person’s feeling state – sharing their emotional experience” (Piasecky 2003: 44). In clinical terms, it is the ability “to recognize and understand the patient’s experience and the emotions associated with it ... it is not about the doctor’s feelings, but how s/he demonstrates this understanding to the patient (Bylund, cited in Watson 2012: 9). In contrast, sympathy describes the doctor/listener’s feelings, but not an understanding or sharing of the patient’s emotions (Piasecky 2003: 44). In this distinction, “empathy” is about the feelings of the patient (the person in pain), while “sympathy” is about the feelings of the doctor/listener. After hearing about how someone feels, the sympathiser has an affective reaction of their own, they now feel something, for example, sorrow. Whereas, after hearing about how someone feels, the empathiser perceives and appreciates the affect of the person in pain (along the same continuum, the compassionate gives medication or does whatever necessary to help alleviate the pain). Taking this psychological perspective, sympathy is about the self, while empathy is about the other; it is other-oriented. This distinction points to the role empathy plays in supporting and motivating acts of compassion towards the suffering of others. Being other-oriented motivates purposeful, performative acts of compassion. It is about responding to the needs of others and acting. Bandura makes three points about empathy (2016: 38):

1. Empathy is not hard-wired. However, while we are endowed with the capacity for vicarious arousal, our experience and learning largely determines our level and pattern of empathic reaction (Bandura 2016: 92).
2. Empathy plays a role in survival – what happens to others is predictive of what might happen to oneself and in this sense produces a somatic, proprioceptive response of

affective intentionality and resonance in the body, “The expression of Person A becomes the impression for person B. The body of the second person incorporates the first person, the perception of the other is mediated by her own body” (Schmidsberger and Loffler-Stastka 2018: 71). This becomes a loop, a process of inter-affectivity, “a circular process of impressions and expressions that follow each other emerge” (Schmidsberger and Loffler-Stastka 2018: 71). This is called a process of mutual incorporation, “that the emotion of the other is sensed and experienced with the own body through bodily resonance” (Schmidsberger and Loffler-Stastka 2018: 71).

3. Empathy is a social construction. It supports prosocial behaviours and social connection. The process is an interactional joint engagement and shared involvement. Bandura (2016: 93) notes that our humanistic inclination toward “the other” serves the well-being of both interactants and promotes “helpfulness, sharing, consoling and supportiveness and curbs socially injurious conduct” (Bandura 2016: 94). It is a kind of “being with” another (Schmidsberger and Loffler-Stastka 2018).

This “being with” practice is a prerequisite for compassionate action aimed at relieving the suffering of others. When a person responds empathically to the pain or otherwise of another, they are resonating somatically as well as, it is being argued, linguistically with the experience and the emotional state of another person through the empathiser’s verbal responses. It is understood that the biological response to another’s pain is due to the presence of mirror neurons (Curtin 2022: 73) which produce the affective bodily resonance (Schmidsberge and Loffler-Stastka 2018: 70) in the person who empathises. In expressing empathy we can feel happiness or distress when resonating with others’ positive or negative feelings (Dowling 2018: 750). It is in this bio-social, semiotic state that a person is able to recognise the humanity of the other person and become inclined towards them.

The article by Thomson (this issue) argues that this resonance is achieved through particular language choices. Particular language choices of the empathic listener can activate a resonance in the person in pain. Receiving words which indicate that the experience and pain of another person is understood assists in shifting a person back into emotional regulation. Supporting a person in pain through specific linguistic choices indicates that empathy is a kind of register... “a syndrome, or a cluster of associated variants” (Halliday 2002: 168) realising a configuration of meanings “that are typically associated with a particular situational configuration of field, tenor and mode” (Halliday and Hasan 1985: 38). In this sense, empathy relates to field (the “what” is going on in the situation) through ideational

meaning related to emotions, feelings, needs, values, wants and desires. It relates to tenor (the “who” is involved in the situation) through sharing and seeking understanding via exchanges of statements and questions, and to mode (how the “what” and the “who” are connected) through a particular arrangement of Theme (the point of departure of a message) and newsworthy information. Words matter, and particular words matter for particular purposes. To mean empathically means to select from the syndrome of associated variants within the register.

In summary, empathy is a compassion-inducing, social semiotic process of “being with” a person, hearing and understanding their feelings and experiences, and producing a somatic resonance within each person. Empathy is a prerequisite for compassion; with empathy comes compassion.

3. Overview of the articles in the special issue

In a demonstration of how a functional linguistic perspective offers a comprehensive framework for dissecting the intricate interplay between language, society and cognition, the contributors to the SI have delved into the semiotic tapestry woven by linguistic resources in varied genres and registers and in diverse contexts. The research articles uncover the myriad ways in which linguistic analysis can be harnessed to catalyse positive change.

Wijeyewardene and Martin and Cruz explore peace in relation to social justice. Both articles illustrate how CDA and PDA can provide complementary perspectives of discourse in the service of power and discourses in the pursuit of peace.

Wijeyewardene in “Constructing resistance in the quest for social justice: A study of a fracturing in Thai hegemony” draws on the concept of social justice as positive peace and illustrates how both CDA and PDA can be applied to the long-running political conflict in Thailand. The paper examines two Thai texts and presents linguistic evidence of a fundamental crack in Thai royalist hegemony. The paper explores how a term of oppression was reconceptualised as a term of pride and subsequently adopted by participants in a social movement struggling to change prevailing structures of political participation and representation. The paper also illustrates how the tools of SFL can productively be applied to Thai language texts to uncover processes of domination and of emancipation. While the struggle for social and political equality in Thailand still has some way to go, a focus on the

use of language in context helps explain the impetus that underpins efforts to continue the struggle and the directions that struggle is likely to take.

Martin and Cruz in “Acknowledging dispossession: A CDA/PDA perspective on discourse dealing with unceded land”, make a strong case for the value for both CDA and PDA of a detailed, discourse semantic analysis using the tools of SFL to explore their data. Their initial focus is the English version of a bilingual text that acknowledges the dispossession of Indigenous people that has occurred as a result of colonialism. The text comprises elements of story and history genres, combining both recognition of past wrongs and the effects of dispossession on indigenous peoples. The paper compares the first text with a speech by Paul Keating, former prime minister of Australia and points to the need for explicit recognition of the hurt brought about by dispossession and to make peace with the dispossessed through new genres that realise semiotic acts of acknowledgement, apology and reconciliation. The acknowledgement of country is one such emerging genre in this process of reconciliation and peace-making. The recent result of the voice referendum in Australia is evidence that there is more work to do to identify areas for collaborative as well as renovatory and peace-building discourses.

Etaywe in “Compassion as appraisal, performative identity, and moral affiliation: A corpus perspective and digital activist strategic communication analysis” tackles two key questions. The first delves into the conceptualisation of compassion, with a specific emphasis on its appraisal nature. This is evidenced in the study of the lemma “compassion” within the Coronavirus Corpus. This analysis serves as the foundation for comprehending the use and overall meaning of this lexical item in recent discursive contexts. It also establishes evidence of its action-oriented and ethics-driven essence, which serves as a ground for responding to the second question – which pertains to how compassion as moral performance is developed and cultivated in digital activist campaigns. The article incorporates the latest advancements in the theorisation of tenor and communion affiliation into the analysis of compassion in digital activism. This subject for analysis is of public interest due to (i) the increasing prevalence of public discourse where digital calls for action have become the norm, and (ii) the contextual backdrop of the digital texts used – specifically, the ongoing Israeli occupation of Palestinian territories, the treatment of Palestinians, and the Australian grassroots reaction to these events. The article sheds light on the role of language in non-violent resistance – specifically in raising awareness about the suffering of others (*communication* function) and in *communion*. It presents the patterns of language use and strategies, revealing assumptions about humanised and moralised allegiances, offering alternative positionings, and

constructing a moral framework and social affiliation, all in anticipation of potential responsive actions. It also provides insights into strategies for effectively conducting activist campaigns that position others through moral propositions and proposals, urging people towards specific purposeful social actions, seen as acts of compassion and integral to an ongoing process of *attitudinal authentication* (Etaywe, this issue). Furthermore, the study demonstrates how language is wielded to align identities and position individuals within shared moral and sociocultural frameworks. It illustrates how clusters of attitudinal bonds and master sociocultural frames serve to amplify the call on targeted audiences to act in accordance with the shared moral orders activated as shared fields. The article's focus on "moral affiliation" as a model for explaining compassion development as a social discursive process holds special interest for other social media activist groups, aspiring to generate alignments with their causes that translate into tangible responses and societal change, through "encouraging acts of compassion" as proactive moral agency (e.g. petitioning, demonstrations, sanctions) and "discouraging immoral behaviour" as a form of inhibitive moral agency (e.g. boycotting).

Fryer in "Feeling, thinking, acting: An intersemiotic study of empathy and compassion in vegan discourse" explores the multi- and intersemiotic expression of empathy and compassion in a media campaign designed to promote veganism through evoking empathy and compassion. The article uses analytic categories of systemic functional semiotics for language, image and music to describe the different modalities of the media campaign. The article demonstrates how instances of attitude in the campaign's various texts are negotiated and shared, creating potentials for empathetic and compassionate responses. The study shows how parts of the campaign promote empathy and compassion, as exemplars for readers to follow, and/or invite the readers to *enact* empathy and compassion. The study also suggests that clusters of positive and negative attitude can form the basis for empathetic and compassionate responses. The article helps us further our understanding of the semiotics of empathy and compassion through illustrating the relation of meaning-making to potential action. The article emphasises the connection between empathy and compassion. It also highlights and provides evidence of differences such as "potentials for empathetic reaction can be formed around positive or negative affect, but compassion seems to be a response to negative feelings or experiences only" [page ref. to come]. The article also stresses the role of cognitive processes, primarily "knowing" about the suffering or pain of animals to invite the readers to act compassionately "by becoming vegan or volunteering at a sanctuary without necessarily feeling the pain or suffering of other animals" [page ref. to come]. In relation to

the negotiated empathetic or compassionate responses, the article also explains how “different semiotic systems contribute in different ways to creating or attempting to create potentials for shared response” [page ref. to come].

The articles by Thomson, Dreyfus and Han, and Ortu pertain to empathy. Thomson describes a partial set of lexicogrammatical features of a designed discourse of empathy, Dreyfus and Han equate compassion with “empathy activism”, while Ortu offers a multimodal analysis of a union website which takes an empathic approach to its identity and membership.

Thomson in “Empathic listening as a social semiotic practice within the tradition of Nonviolent Communication (NVC): An analysis of choices in thematic progression and information structure”, identifies a particular discourse of compassion as an alternative semiotic practice to regressive, hegemonic discourse. The article draws on the complementary perspectives of PDA with the intention of providing a partial linguistic description of empathic listening for sharing, learning and teaching. Being empathic and knowing how to act as an empathic listener is not always modelled in people’s lives, yet this kind of semiotic practice is a means for building and maintaining personal and interpersonal connection. It serves to bring people together, recognising our common humanity and the reality that our very survival depends on our capacity to function effectively and cooperatively across and within various orders of social organisation. Being empathic is a very positive, useful skill to have and can be taught if required. The article aims to provide a partial set of linguistic features of empathy for underpinning any future learning/teaching resources. The article begins with a discussion on the notion of empathy, drawing on psychological and medical understandings, followed by a short history and description of NVC, as designed by Marshall Rosenberg (2015). Thomson applies SFL analytical tools to a small corpus of 11 dyads of empathy which were recorded during a variety of NVC events over a two-year period. The study uses Appraisal theory, notably that of Attitude, to interrogate the interpersonal meanings and maps how these meanings are coupled ideationally and arranged textually across the systems of THEME and INFORMATION STATUS. The analysis reveals a particular pattern of thematic progression which is described as “a pattern of co-created, continuous thematic progression of resonated new information”. Thomson argues that this particular linguistic patterning is what resonates between empathisers and empathisees in NVC. It is what supports a person-in-pain to reach self-regulation following some kind of somatic trigger. Simultaneously the empathiser

experiences “appreciative perception” which motivates them to action. In other words, with empathy come acts of compassion.

Ortu’s paper, “The place of feelings and the rise of the empathetic union”, describes the semiotic resources deployed during the creation of the Alphabet Workers Union (AWU) in 2021, focusing on the development of its identity as one of “empathic workers who believe in social justice”. The article analyses the homepage of the AWU’s website using a multimodal approach based on the textual metafunction as visual mode (Kress and van Leeuwen 2001, 2006) and Appraisal theory. The significance of this study lies in the AWU’s novel innovation to union organising by introducing language based on positive feelings of belonging, togetherness and protection. The union member is promised an empathic community where a sense of togetherness is developed. This kind of multimodal meaning making is not usually present in union communications; however, the motivation behind such a significant change in language and thus identity at the AWU was to increase membership, which was successful. The article demonstrates linguistically how this was done. Further, it demonstrates that a multimodal discourse of connection and empathy can attract and increase union membership.

The link between empathy and compassion that we have been exploring in this SI is central to the purpose of the text analysed in Dreyfus and Han’s article “From empathy to activism: an analysis of a letter to the Minister which resulted in successful outcomes for a person with severe intellectual disability and their family”. Dreyfus and Han present this letter as an example of the written genre of hortatory exposition (Martin and Peters 1985/2012), and demonstrate how the phases in the unfolding argument can be delineated using resources from the Appraisal and Connexion frameworks. The success of the argument (the *logos*, in Aristotelian terms) of this hortatory text depends on its interweaving with *ethos* (how the letter-writer Dreyfus indicates authority and builds rapport with the intended audience, the Minister and their officers) and with *pathos*. For Dreyfus and Han, the text succeeds by “making ‘my’ problem, ‘your’ problem” [page ref. to come], and this shift from “me” to “we” is linguistic shorthand for the mission of “empathy activism”.

4. Final remarks

This SI is a showcase of the power of semiotic choices that can serve as a potential agent of transformation. Through the lens of various analytical frameworks, it contributes to our

understanding of the discourses and semiotics of peace, compassion and empathy, and how to advance positive social change far from violence. It dissects the nuances of choices and uncovers their profound social implications. It also serves to equip discourse analysts, interested in making positive change in the world, with some tools necessary to navigate the complexities of online and offline communication. Through such progressive linguistic projects, linguists may inform the ways towards more peaceful, compassionate and empathic discourses and towards fostering connections that transcend linguistic, political and cultural divides.

In conclusion, “peace”, or the desire for “peace”, exists in multiple domains: peace within oneself, between people, or between groups, nations, cultures and the ecosystem. It is both a state of being and an action, and necessitates social justice, equality and the practices of empathy and compassion. Empathy and compassion are in a continuum. “Empathy” is a compassion-inducing, social semiotic process of “being with” a person, hearing and understanding their feelings and experiences, and producing a somatic resonance within each person. “Compassion” is to morally and humanely “feel for” others and act to alleviate their suffering. It extends beyond triggered emotions, expressing institutionalised feelings and ethics. Its essence is purposefully performative and other-oriented. It involves experiencing or knowing about the pain or suffering of others, coupled with the desire or motivation to alleviate their suffering and an enabling performance that includes one’s own action or the actions of others. This SI is proof of the fact that we, individuals and groups, stand at the frontier of positive change, armed with the tools to forge a more harmonious and interconnected future - that is, the tools to understand how language and other semiotic resources function in discourse for good or evil.

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